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The poem describes an act of chivalry, gallantry, patriotism and sacrifice on the part of a young French soldier.

You know, we French **stormed Ratisbon**:
A mile or so away,
On a little **mound**, Napoleon
Stood on our storming-day;
With neck **out-thrust**, you **fancy** how,
Legs wide, arms locked behind,
As if to balance the **prone** brow
Oppressive with its mind. 8

Just as perhaps he **mused**, 'My plans
That soar, to earth may fall,
Let once my army-leader **Lannes**
Waver at yonder wall', –
Out 'twixt the battery-smokes there flew
A rider, bound on bound
Full-galloping: nor **bridle** drew
Until he reached the mound. 16

Then off there flung in smiling joy,
And held himself erect
By just his horse's mane, a boy:
You hardly could suspect –
(So tight he kept his lips **compressed**,
Scarce any blood came through)
You looked twice ere you saw his breast
Was all but shot in two. 24

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